

are now even more unwilling to pay for software that have free replacements, and services and infrastructure that are tightly coupled to proprietary systems are on the economic decline thus forcing 'capitalist' companies to increasingly support the creation of 'free as in freedom' databases, programming languages, Web browsers, kernels, operating systems for mobile and tablet platforms, among others. The unwillingness to pay for digital produce began as a reaction to the exorbitant costs of artifacts that had only a one time production cost, and the act of 'digital piracy' was a sub-conscious protest.

Proprietary software companies adapted to this 'reaction' by actively encouraging 'piracy' among individual users and even legalising it for educational use. However, those penalised for 'piracy' were small, medium and large scale businesses. With free software assuming economic significance, several large corporations are investing in free software under the guise of 'open source' to ensure that they continue to enable their erstwhile monopoly. Eben Moglen's narrative of how '... the struggle for freedom of knowledge is associated with the struggle for human equality...' in his talk on 'Free Software and the Struggle for Free Thought' provides us with a historical perspective of the factors and forces that seek to proprietise knowledge via software.

Does this mean that free software will only flourish as open source in a capitalist economic model? Richard Stallman gives a good explanation of 'Why free software is better than open source' (<https://www.gnu.org/philosophy/free-software-for-freedom.html>) and 'Why open source misses the point of free software' (<https://www.gnu.org/philosophy/open-source-misses-the-point.html>). Using the concept of dialectics, if we consider proprietary software to be the 'thesis' and free software to be the 'anti-thesis' then open source would be the 'synthesis'. The open source definition came about in 1998 after intense ideological confrontation between the two opposite camps—one of knowledge production and consumption, and the other of monopolising knowledge for economic gains and power. Currently, the synthesis within the dialectics is positioned closer to the free

software paradigm though one can observe tendencies to adopt techniques that closely resemble proprietary companies. For example, the open source definition rejects or dilutes the ideological and ethical standpoints and focuses only on the development methodology.

A deeper observation of the active proponents of the open source camp reveals that they share socio-political-economic characteristics that are similar, though not necessarily identical, to proponents of proprietary software. The free software movement, by constantly adopting positive developments in both the open source community and proprietary software that did not conflict with its basic tenets of ethics and the welfare of society, and by adapting to newer challenges, could ensure that the synthesis remains closer to the free software paradigm.

The free software movement actively works towards human growth by creating a healthy environment that fosters healthy competition and economic productivity, unlike the proprietary model, which is a product of capitalist production that actively works towards a monopoly. In this context, everything that is right, just and serves humanity is free software.  **END**

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